

The Waterfront Brief

Weekly sustainment intelligence for naval shipyard leadership · Naval shipbuilding, ship repair, and fleet sustainment

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This issue covers four stories and two things to watch. The first is Norfolk Naval Shipyard reorganising itself around single points of accountability, read against what the research says a reorganisation can and cannot do. The second is the promise made under that structure, the Ford back in six months with the fire run as a second availability. The third is two decisions that moved a date by moving scope, at San Diego and at Newport News. The fourth is a destroyer that lost power in the South China Sea and the Philippine yard that took it, which is now getting a longer pier.

Labels: FACT is attributed to the named source in the same sentence; Assessment is this desk's analysis, built only on facts stated above it; Speculation is flagged as such; Unverified marks a claim this desk could not check against a primary source, with the reason given.

BUSINESS PRACTICES & STRATEGY

Norfolk gave every shop one owner, and the research says that is the easy half

Norfolk Naval Shipyard has redrawn its command structure so that one person answers for production, one for nuclear work, and one each for support, business and the command itself. It is the first public yard to reorganise around the sustainment programme it has been running for five years, and it has put a date on the wall to be judged by.

FACT: Norfolk announced on September 2 that it “has recently launched” a Command and Control reorganisation under a five-person Executive Steering Committee that “provides single points of accountability across the shipyard’s focal areas,” per the shipyard’s release on DVIDS. FACT: the same release puts Codes 200, 300C, 300S, 700 and 900 under an Executive Director of Production Operations, Capt. Bart Sievenpiper, as “the single accountable person for production execution across the shipyard,” puts nuclear engineering, radiological controls and nuclear production (Codes 105, 300N and 2309) under a separate director, Jeremy Largey, and groups industrial support, business and command support under three more. FACT: the shipyard commander, Rear Adm. Kavon Hakimzadeh, said the structure was designed “to

establish clear, unified chains of command so that the right ‘supported and supporting’ relationships are set,” and Largey said “in this initial pilot over the last year, we saw key areas of improvement that needed to be made,” per the same release. Supported and supporting is the military’s way of saying who a task belongs to and who serves it.

The structure serves an execution model the yard has been building for a year. FACT: Norfolk’s July 8 release on the Ford’s arrival described its Focus and Finish model as “starting availability jobs and urgently working them to completion to minimize interruptions and delays,” and quoted a project official on using it “to minimize multitasking, drive scheduling discipline, and rapidly close out work areas.” FACT: the yard said on July 1 that its transformation office runs Focus and Finish mechanic workshops “where cross-functional stakeholders work together to streamline small-scope processes,” about one every two weeks, developed after a visit to Portsmouth Naval Shipyard, with the first sessions joined by Portsmouth, Puget Sound and Pearl Harbor and aimed at jobs the size of a freeze seal or a valve repack, per DVIDS. FACT: the yard launched a monthly State of the Shipyard forum on August 26, streamed to the workforce, at which the reorganisation was briefed, per its September 2 release.

The results it points to are carrier dates. FACT: Norfolk said on April 24 that USS Dwight D. Eisenhower’s planned incremental availability was “the SECOND consecutive early finish of an aircraft carrier availability” at the yard, after Bush in November 2024, and that the team executed “more than 25,000 resource days of new work” while “saving 2,000 resource days,” per DVIDS. A resource day is one person working one day.

What the research says a structure can do. FACT: Casciaro, Edmondson and Jang wrote in Harvard Business Review in 2019 that “one way to break down silos is to redesign the formal organizational structure. But that approach has limits: It’s costly, confusing, and slow. Worse, every new structure solves some problems but creates others.” FACT: the same article reports that in studies of more than 2,000 teams, diverse teams

that contained a “cultural broker,” a person who works both sides of a boundary, significantly outperformed teams without one, and names four practices that cross silos: brokers, asking the right questions, taking the other side’s perspective, and knowing where the expertise is.

Assessment: the reorganisation fixes the vertical problem, who owns production, and the research says the interfaces are horizontal. The seam between production and nuclear did not go away on September 2; it now runs between two directors instead of through a matrix, and a valve repack still needs the machinist, the nuclear engineer and the tester in the same week. Norfolk’s workshops are the broker mechanism the research describes, small, cross-functional and frequent, and they predate the boxes, which is the right order. The prediction is that the structure shows up in the numbers the yard already publishes, resource days saved on the next carrier and the next submarine, and that the other three public yards adopt the directorate model within a year, because the Naval Sustainment System programme they all sit in rewards what Norfolk can show. The Ford’s date is the wrong test of the structure, for the reasons the next article gives. The risk is the one the research names: a structure that solves accountability creates a new problem at the seams it draws, and the seams here are nuclear.

Bottom line: before redrawing your own chart, find the people your yard already uses to get a job across a code boundary and give them a two-week cadence and a small scope; give production one owner only when the seams it creates, nuclear first, have a named broker on each side; and watch Norfolk’s resource-day numbers, not its org chart, for whether this worked.

Sources: NNSY via DVIDS, Sep 2, 2026; NNSY via DVIDS, Sep 2, 2026 (forum); NNSY via DVIDS, Jul 1, 2026; U.S. Navy, Jul 8, 2026; NNSY via DVIDS, Apr 24, 2026; Casciaro, Edmondson and Jang, HBR, May-June 2019

OPERATIONS MAINTENANCE & READINESS

The Ford in six months: the promise, the mechanism and the arithmetic against it

Norfolk’s commander has promised the fleet a carrier back in six months after the longest deployment since Vietnam and a fire, and the way he intends to keep it is to run the fire as a second availability on the same ship. The date was set before either happened, and the plan has not said where the growth goes or who integrates two availabilities on one hull.

FACT: USS Gerald R. Ford arrived at Norfolk on July 7 for its first planned incremental availability, the first time a Ford-class carrier has been serviced at the yard, and “a concurrent availability will be conducted to restore spaces damaged during a fire aboard the then-deployed carrier in March,” per the Navy’s July 8 release. A planned incremental availability is a carrier’s scheduled maintenance period between deployments. FACT: USNI News reported on July 14 that such availabilities “are typically scheduled for six to eight months” and that the fire started in the aft laundry and spread to berthing.

FACT: Breaking Defense reported on September 14 that Rear Adm. Hakimzadeh said “it was 10 months, I promised the Fleet commander we could do it in six months. So we set that in place while she was on deployment before she had a fire... I’m still going to deliver that ship back in six months, but we’ve set up a second availability that is overseen by the regional maintenance center with a commercial partner, with a commercial vendor, that is running that availability.” FACT: the same report says he allowed for “follow up” and “clean up” at the end, that the ship spent 326 days at sea, and that the acting Secretary of the Navy, Hung Cao, told House appropriators in May that “for every 30 days that the ship is extended on deployment, it adds 6 percent of maintenance, so five months extra would add 30 percent for maintenance.”

Assessment: the six-month figure was set before the deployment ended and before the fire, and nothing announced since has added time to it, while the Navy’s own rule of thumb adds 30 percent of maintenance for the extension alone, growth that lands in the planned package, not the fire one. A vendor’s people speed work only where the work is separable, and a laundry and berthing rebuild is not separable from the ship: its power, ventilation and firemain run through systems the yard is working in the same months, under the same tag-outs and the same test programme. Two availabilities on one hull is two work-authorisation and test streams on shared systems, and nothing announced says who integrates them. The prediction is that the planned availability closes near its date, that what does not fit moves into the fire availability and the “clean up,” and that the ship is not back with the fleet in six months in the sense the fleet commander was promised. If it is, the desk will say so.

Bottom line: do not copy this yet. The questions for Norfolk, and for anyone proposing the same on your pier: who integrates the two work-authorisation and test streams at the systems they share, where the 30 percent from the extension is provisioned, and which of the two dates the fleet was promised. Watch the Ford for two dates, not one.

Sources: *U.S. Navy*, Jul 8, 2026; *USNI News*, Jul 14, 2026; *Breaking Defense*, Sep 14, 2026

Two decisions that moved a date by moving scope

An amphibious ship undocked on time in San Diego because the yard contracted for growth work before it found any, and a new submarine skipped its post-delivery repair period because its trials were clean. Both are scope decisions, and both defer something.

FACT: Southwest Regional Maintenance Center said on September 15 that USS America (LHA 6) undocked on time on August 11 in its Chief of Naval Operations availability, and quoted the project manager, Jorge Mota, crediting “proactive risk mitigation, disciplined planning, and an agile contracting strategy designed to address potential growth work early,” per NAVSEA; the same release defines growth work as “additional repairs identified once systems and structural compartments are opened” and says the availability completes in 2027. FACT: NASSCO announced in May 2025 that it was awarded a \$198,955,270 firm-fixed-price contract for the availability, with options to \$209,233,949 and completion expected by July 2027. FACT: GAO reported in May 2020 that the Navy’s multiple-award contracting strategy for ship repair relies on fixed-price awards, and described a congressional pilot meant to “mitigate schedule delays typically associated with growth work,” per GAO-20-370.

FACT: the Navy said on August 17 that it waived the post-shakedown availability of USS Massachusetts (SSN 798), delivered by Newport News in November 2025 and commissioned in March, with the Chief of Naval Operations saying the decision “allows our shipbuilding workforce to focus its talent and capacity where we need it most, building the next generation of submarines,” and Vice Adm. Rob Gaucher calling it “a calculated risk.” A post-shakedown availability is the yard period after delivery in which deficiencies found in a new ship’s first months are corrected. FACT: GAO reported in 2017 that the Navy “regularly accepts ships with numerous deficiencies,” that it “pays for the vast majority of shipbuilder-responsible deficiencies discovered after the Navy takes delivery,” and that

across six ships the count of significant construction deficiencies fell from 363 at delivery to 45 by the time the ships were provided to the fleet, per GAO-17-418.

Assessment: SWRMC has named a method and not described it, and under a fixed-price award growth work is priced as it is found, which is the delay GAO describes, so “address growth early” most likely means growth capacity priced or optioned before the ship opened; that is this desk’s inference, and an undocking date is not a completion. The Massachusetts decision is clearer: a post-shakedown period is where a new ship’s deficiencies get fixed at the builder’s expense, and waiving it on a boat with clean trials moves whatever surfaces later into the fleet’s first depot availability, paid from the maintenance account. The prediction is that Massachusetts’s first availability carries work that would have been the shipbuilder’s, and that more Block IV boats with clean trials get the same waiver, because the capacity argument the CNO made does not change from hull to hull.

Bottom line: ask SWRMC’s planners how growth was provided for in the America order before your next task order is written, and when a post-shakedown availability is waived on a hull headed for your pier, get the list of what it would have corrected, because that list is now yours.

Sources: *NAVSEA*, Sep 15, 2026; *General Dynamics NASSCO*, May 21, 2025; *GAO-20-370*; *U.S. Navy*, Aug 17, 2026; *GAO-17-418*

WATERFRONT OPS & PRODUCTION

The pier the Benfold went to is getting longer

A destroyer that lost power in the South China Sea was towed to Subic Bay and met there by people from Yokosuka, and the American-owned yard that took it has a US-funded study to extend its pier to a berth a destroyer fits.

FACT: USNI News reported on August 15 that USS Benfold (DDG 65) reported a generator casualty with loss of power on July 24 in the Indo-Pacific, that sailors were “without galley services, toilets and air conditioning,” that contractor tugs towed the ship to Subic Bay “where it was met by personnel from the Ship Repair Facility - Japan Regional Maintenance Center on July 28,” that power was restored on July 30, and that repairs were completed by August 7. FACT: USNI News reported on September 14 that the Subic Drydock Corporation, “an American-owned firm operating out of the former U.S. naval station,” has a \$1.4

million feasibility study from the US Trade and Development Agency to extend its approach pier by 169 metres, which the firm says would create a usable berth of more than 270 metres and “allow us to accommodate larger vessels and undertake repairs that are currently not possible due to draft and berth limitations,” and that under its Master Ship Repair Agreement the yard has serviced expeditionary fast transports and littoral combat ships. A Master Ship Repair Agreement is NAVSEA’s certification that a private yard may bid on Navy repair work.

Assessment: the Benfold job is what forward emergent repair looks like in practice: the forward yard’s people travel to where the hull is, and the hull goes to the nearest pier that can take it. That pier today takes fast transports and small combatants under its agreement; a destroyer alongside for two weeks was a casualty response, not a capability. The extension is a study, so the earliest a longer berth exists is years out, and the study’s own words say the constraint is draft as much as length. The prediction is that Subic’s next Navy work after the study is a destroyer’s planned pier-side period rather than another tow, because the yard now has both the agreement and the proof of demand, and that the draft limit, not the pier, decides which hulls.

Bottom line: if you plan emergent work for 7th Fleet, put Subic on the list now as the destroyer-capable pier it is about to become, and ask the Yokosuka team who went what the Benfold job needed that the yard could not provide; that gap is the requirement the study should be written to.

Sources: USNI News, Aug 15, 2026; USNI News, Sep 14, 2026

Two things to watch

Two developments that are not yet stories.

FACT: the department’s contract list for September 3 records a \$47,768,691 firm-fixed-price award to Integrated Solutions for Systems of Huntsville “for expeditionary maintenance and repair facility (EMRF) production,” for “five fully outfitted EMRFs, consisting of 90 individual expeditionary maintenance and repair container (EMRC) prototype units and four additional fully outfitted EMRC variants,” to be “deployed globally to diverse

environments where the government will use them as data collection platforms to validate the EMRF concept,” complete by September 2027. Expeditionary here means forward: these are the pre-staged repair packages No. 9 described, loaded by SIMA sailors for a repair availability outside the maintenance plan, with a 72-hour arrival objective.

FACT: the commanding officers of SIMA San Diego and SIMA Norfolk said on September 3 that their commands, re-established in June, are rotating sailors “through multiple shops” instead of one specialty, adding a mandatory four-week onboarding assessment, and will conduct shipboard maintenance “in direct coordination with Forward Deployed Regional Maintenance Center personnel,” per DVIDS.

Assessment: these are the two ends of one intermediate level. The SIMAs sit at the homeports and take intermediate-level work back from the depots and the contractors; the containers carry a repair package forward to a ship that cannot get home, packed by the same sailors. What the enterprise gains is sailor-manned repair at both ends of a deployment. The prediction is that once the test reports, the emergent and intermediate-level work that today accumulates until a hull reaches a depot pier arrives there less often, and the packages that do arrive carry less of it.

Bottom line: September 2027 is when the container test reports. Until then, go through the emergent and intermediate-level items in your last three packages and mark the ones that only came to you because there was nowhere else to do them, forward or at the homeport; that is the work the containers and the SIMAs are for.

Sources: DoW contracts, Sep 3, 2026; SIMA via DVIDS, Sep 10, 2026

The Waterfront Brief is compiled weekly by the B2 vault’s research engine from primary sources and verified trade reporting. Scope: US shipbuilding, US Navy sustainment, and partners across the Indo-Pacific region; out-of-area items only when there is a direct, stated lesson. Freshness policy: every article’s anchor source is under 12 months old; older material appears only as dated context or a flagged exception. FACT means the named source says it, not that this desk has independently verified it. Corrections welcome; staged sources are retained for audit.

UPCOMING EVENTS

Nearest first, filling the page. **Bold** marks a decision that closes inside the next 60 days. ASNE is the American Society of Naval Engineers; NSRP is the National Shipbuilding Research Program, the industry-Navy body that funds shared shipyard process research.

Dates	Event	Register by	Why it matters
Sep 22-24, 2026	FMMS 2026 (Fleet Maintenance & Modernization Symposium), Virginia Beach, VA (ASNE)	Open; early bird closed Aug 16	Maintenance execution / regional capacity: the maintenance community's own event; NSRP's Sustainment Panel meets there Sep 23
Oct 20-21, 2026	NSRP Workforce & Compliance and Production Planning Joint Panel, Pensacola, FL (NSRP)	Open, no deadline	Workforce and production-planning panels, jointly; virtual option
Nov 12-13, 2026	Naval Submarine League Annual Symposium 2026, Arlington, VA (NSL)	To be posted	Submarine industrial base: the submarine force and its yards set the year's priorities
Dec 8-11, 2026	Department of War Maintenance Symposium 2026, Fort Lauderdale, FL (SAE for DoW)	Open, no deadline	Maintenance execution: the department-wide depot maintenance meeting
Jan 12-14, 2027	SNA National Symposium 2027, Arlington, VA (SNA)	Not yet open	Programme priorities: where the surface force states its maintenance priorities
Jan 26-28, 2027	Military Additive Manufacturing Summit (MILAM), Tampa, FL (DSI)	Next tier closes Oct 2	Additive qualification: defense additive qualification and NAVSEA-spec adoption
Feb 16-18, 2027	WEST 2027, San Diego, CA (AFCEA/USNI)	Not printed	Programme priorities: the Pacific-side sea services conference
Mar 23-25, 2027	NSRP All Panel Meeting 2027, North Charleston, SC (NSRP)	"Coming soon"	Regional capacity: where yard R&D ideas get teamed programme-wide
Apr 4-7, 2027	Sea-Air-Space 2027, National Harbor, MD (Navy League)	Open, no deadline	Programme priorities: the largest US maritime defense exposition
Apr 11-15, 2027	AMPP Annual Conference + Expo 2027, Columbus, Ohio (AMPP)	Abstracts due Oct 1	Preservation: the corrosion and coatings profession's main event
Jun 8-10, 2027	MegaRust 2027, Hampton, VA (ASNE)	Not yet open; exhibitor presale, public from Sep 21	Maintenance execution: the Navy corrosion event
Nov 2-4, 2027	Indo Pacific 2027 International Maritime Exposition, Sydney (AMDA Foundation)	Not published yet	Supply chain / policy engagement: the Pacific's naval industry exposition; allied yards exhibit